

## **ST Pat's Policy on team Mentors' interactions with underage Referees**

Creating pathways for young people to participate in our games is not just as players but by also affording them other developmental opportunities including training to become referees.

All underage referees undertake an approved certified programme which ensures their knowledge of the strict guidelines for refereeing underage matches. It also promotes impartiality, safeguarding of young players, constructive communication relevant to the age group, and upholding of the "Give Respect – Get Respect" initiative.

Parents and mentors have a key role in supporting these young referees. Adult behaviour is highly scrutinized by juvenile players, and parents and mentors, are expected to accept the referee's authority without dissent, set a positive example for fair play, and encourage juveniles players to respect the referee at all times.

Mentors should instil in their players respect towards our underage referees at all times and should lead by example by not shouting at or talking back to the referee.

All Mentors are required to wear bibs at matches so that the referee can easily identify who is a mentor and who is not.

**St Pats** has a policy for underage matches (CCC1&2) that the lead mentor or their nominee for the given match is the **only** mentor to engage directly with the referee, unless there is a player safety issue. This allows the referee to focus on overseeing the match and other mentors to focus on supporting their team. It also prevents distraction of juvenile players and supports modelling of good behaviour for our players.

Engagement between Referees and mentors should be minimal at halftime and only really if there is a patient safety issue. Once the match is over, it is beneficial for mentors to talk with our underage referees, discussing in a constructive way decisions made, which assists building positive relationships and the confidence and skills of our underage referees.

### **Dealing with Breaches**

If misconduct occurs—such as abuse from coaches, parents, or players —the referee must report it to the Referee co-ordinator or Juvenile chair or club children's officer at St Pats.

Breaches of the code may be handled informally by the Club or County Children's Officer or referred to a formal Code of Behaviour Hearings Committee, which can lead to sanctions or temporary suspensions from competitions as per *code of conduct*.

**Breaches of St Pat's policy of 1 identified mentor only to engage with underage referees** will lead to a suspension of the unnominated mentor from attending

matches as a given team mentor x 4weeks. A recurrent breach could lead to permanent ban from attending juvenile matches for given team as a mentor.

Where a mentor has to be suspended from acting as a mentor for matches for a fixed period of time, it is expected that all other team mentors will support adherence to this policy and model good behaviours for both their players and our underage referees.

| Action                                                                                                                                           | Responsible                                                   |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Referee arrives 10mins prior to match start time to allow time to meet with both team's mentors.                                                 | Underage Referee                                              |
| All mentors <b>identified</b> with bibs                                                                                                          | Team Mentors                                                  |
| <b>Lead Mentor or nominated lead</b> to interact with underage referee for given match to be identified to referee prior to start of game        | Team lead/nominated Mentor                                    |
| Once match finishes. Referees and lead/named mentors have <b>constructive discussion</b> on decisions to assist referees learning and confidence | Team lead/nominated Mentor and Referee                        |
| Referee reports breach of St Pats policy of <b>one named mentor</b> to referee co-ordinator                                                      | Juvenile Chair/Childrens officer advise mentor of suspension. |
| Referee to report and follow learning from certified referee program for all other breaches/misconduct                                           | Referee co-ordinator/club childrens officer.                  |

**Policy Agreed & Endorsed by St Pats Executive;**

**Chairperson**

**Date**

Review date Sept 2028. Policy owner Club Childrens Officer

## REFERENCES

Maintaining appropriate levels of behaviour in our work with children and young people Young Players, Coaches, Supporters, Parents/Guardians, Referees and Clubs. <https://www.gaa.ie/api/pdfs/image/upload/tgt2wj098wpkinj58pfd.pdf>

Give Respect, Get Respect

<https://www.gaa.ie/the-gaa/rules-regulations/respect>

GAA Code of Behaviour and Child Safeguarding Policy Statement

<https://www.gaa.ie/api/pdfs/image/upload/gh96alunyhh5qa9bczoo.pdf>